lacking vital equipment for prolonged warfare. One shortcoming after another. Netanyahu is aware of the political battle he will have to fight against enormous odds after the war, and this prospect appears to paralyze him, even beyond his usual procrastination and caution.

Regarding the IDF, its lack of readiness on October 7 is obvious. On the other hand, it may have been preparing for a war in Gaza for quite some time, as a recent article published by the *Telegraph* appears to confirm. According to the *Telegraph*, the Israeli army some time ago set up a replica Gazan city in the Negev Desert near Tze'Elim; it's even known as "Little Gaza" and mimics the enclave's terrain and infrastructure, including its tunnels. The article also mentions that the army has "sponge bombs": bombs or explosives projecting foam that immediately solidifies and which can seal passageways in or between tunnels. The article doesn't offer any precise indication for its assertions but gives the impression that the IDF is not entirely unprepared for a ground assault.

According to several commentators, Hamas has already achieved what was possibly its major aim: a renewed international awareness of the Palestinian issue. Over the last two years or so, there has been a distinct possibility that the Abraham Accords between Israel and a number of Arab countries, coupled with a potential normalization of relations between the Jewish state and Saudi Arabia, would marginalize the Palestine issue, and perhaps even make it irrelevant. October 7 drastically changed the situation: now, the Palestinian issue and particularly the setting up of a Palestinian state is on the minds of everyone, including President Biden. For the present Israeli government this may be the most unwelcome perspective.

In a special briefing for foreign correspondents, an IDF spokesperson disclosed considerable intelligence materials intended to prove that Hamas's operational headquarters is located beneath Gaza's largest medical complex, Al-Shifa Hospital.